CRUSHED Vijay at the Karur rally just before tragedy struck, Sept. 27; (below) mourning relatives with the body of a victim



AFP

In the past year, notes political analyst Priyan Srinivasan, Vijay had held six key rallies, mapping out his target electorate and building a narrative that was decidedly confrontational. With the opposition All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) alliance still in disarray, he had been trying to frame the 2026 assembly election as a battle between his fledgling TVK and the DMK. At least a few political observers felt the message had begun to resonate.

The Karur mishap has upended this careful positioning. Vijay's rallies before the tragedy took hard swipes at the DMK and BJP, and projected himself as a credible alternative for voters weary of entrenched party politics. But, as anthropologist Rajan Kurai Krishnan puts it, Tamil Nadu has seen this script before. The state's political history is replete with examples of superstars who failed to translate their screen magic into votes. From Sivaji Ganesan to Kamal Haasan to Rajinikanth, they all realised they could not replicate the legacy of M.G.